Democratic resilience in the age of AI

Concept Note

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Please note: *Do NOT circulate this concept note. This document is not yet the proposal itself. It serves to conceptualize the overarching theoretical framework on which we will develop the work packages, before we draft the actual proposal.*

1 Theoretical framework: informational resilience of democracy

The resilience of democracies worldwide is being tested like never before by mounting internal and external pressures, including inequality, declining trust, governance failures, climate change, and authoritarian aggression, all of which threaten core political actors, democratic institutions and practices. The rapid societal uptake of advanced artificial intelligence (AI) since the early 2020s has compounded some of these pressures while introducing new concerns about the risks of "runaway AI."

Scholars have grappled with these twin developments by identifying the institutional and discursive conditions that underpin democratic resilience (Biddle et al., 2025; Boese et al., 2021; Croissant & Lott, 2026; Dryzek et al., 2019; Ercan et al., 2025; Merkel, 2026), developing frameworks for understanding AI's effects on democracy (Altman, 2026; Garbe & Maerz, 2026; Notley et al., 2026; Schroeder et al., 2026; Summerfield et al., 2025), and examining how AI might strengthen democratic governance and popular participation (König, 2026; Margetts et al., 2024; Noveck, 2026; Tessler et al., 2024). Yet we still lack a systematic account of how AI affects democratic resilience and, consequently, of how policy can maximize its benefits while limiting its risks.

To fill this gap, we propose a new model of informational resilience: it conceptualizes democratic resilience as a property of systems of information feedback, and identifies how AI can undermine or strengthen a system's capacity to sustain or restore its core democratic qualities under pressure. The overarching objective of this project is therefore to diagnose AI-driven erosion of democratic qualities and to develop, test and transfer the tools that counter it. We develop and pilot these tools in the EU and Australia — two consolidated democratic settings with contrasting regulatory environments — and extend the diagnosis to hybrid and backsliding cases in Southeast Asia and the Pacific, where AI's disruptive potential is least constrained. This design yields evidence and instruments that are robust across regulatory regimes rather than specific to one, and directly usable by EU institutions, national decision-makers and civil society organisations.

We define democratic resilience as a political system's capacity to sustain or restore its core democratic qualities under pressure (Biddle et al., 2025; Boese et al., 2021; Croissant & Lott, 2026; Lührmann, 2021; Merkel, 2026), which depends on the system's capacity to gather and process information, make decisions, and respond adequately to citizens' needs. For a democracy to be informationally resilient, citizens must have autonomy to gather information, form opinions and act on their own judgments (Anderson & Pro, 2026; Dahl, 1989), information circulating through the system must have integrity (Dahl, 1989; Habermas, 1962), and institutions must remain accountable for how that information is turned into regulation and policy (Bovens, 2007; Schedler, 1999). All three are a pre-condition for resilience and must work equitably: when only the best-resourced can claim autonomy, integrity, or accountability, that inequality makes democratic backsliding more likely (Lührmann & Lindberg, 2019; Merkel & Lührmann, 2021).

AI disrupts this democratic information loop directly, reshaping how citizens form judgments and how democratic institutions are scrutinised (Farrell, 2026; Jungherr, 2023; Kreps & Kriner, 2023; Wiewiura et al., 2026). Three forms of AI carry this disruption: (1) generative AI, which fabricates content; (2) ranking and recommendation systems, which shape what is seen; and (3) agentic AI, which increasingly executes rather than just informs decisions (Schmid et al., 2026). Each is dual use, in that the same capability that erodes a component by default can strengthen it by design (Cavaliere & Romeo, 2022; König & Wenzelburger, 2022; Noveck, 2026; Ovadya, 2023).

Figure 1 illustrates how we conceptualize informational resilience of democracy through the lens of autonomy, integrity, and accountability, and how different forms of AI disrupt the loop.

1.1 Informational autonomy — citizens

Informational autonomy refers to citizens' capacity to gather information, form opinions, and act based on their own judgments (Anderson & Pro, 2026; Dahl, 1989). Following Anderson & Pro (2026, p. 3), this informational autonomy has two dimensions: *authenticity*, the freedom to form beliefs, values and preferences that are genuinely one's own, arrived at through reflection rather than manipulation; and *agency*, the ability to act effectively on them in private and public life. Both dimensions are unequally distributed, varying systematically with education, gender, socioeconomic status, language, disability, age and digital access, so any investigation on informational autonomy must ask not only whether the overall capacity is strengthened or eroded, but for whom specifically.

AI poses a risk to informational autonomy: the same generative AI systems that help citizens interpret information also help compose what they say, while ranking and recommendation systems shape what they encounter and whether their expressions are able to reach decision-makers, making it harder to tell where a citizen's reasoning ends and the system's contribution begins. This risk is distributional as well. Language models inherit the biases of their training data, over-representing dominant English-speaking, Western and male perspectives, and algorithmic selection may paradoxically exclude affected groups under a claim of "neutrality" — for example Pacific Islanders in deliberations on climate change (Ohren et al., 2026, p. 7). Anderson & Pro (2026) call this tension the *autonomy paradox*: AI can make participation easier while weakening the independence of judgment, or support reflective judgment while constraining citizens' capacity to act on it.

AI can also strengthen informational autonomy. It can reduce the cost of political learning, com-

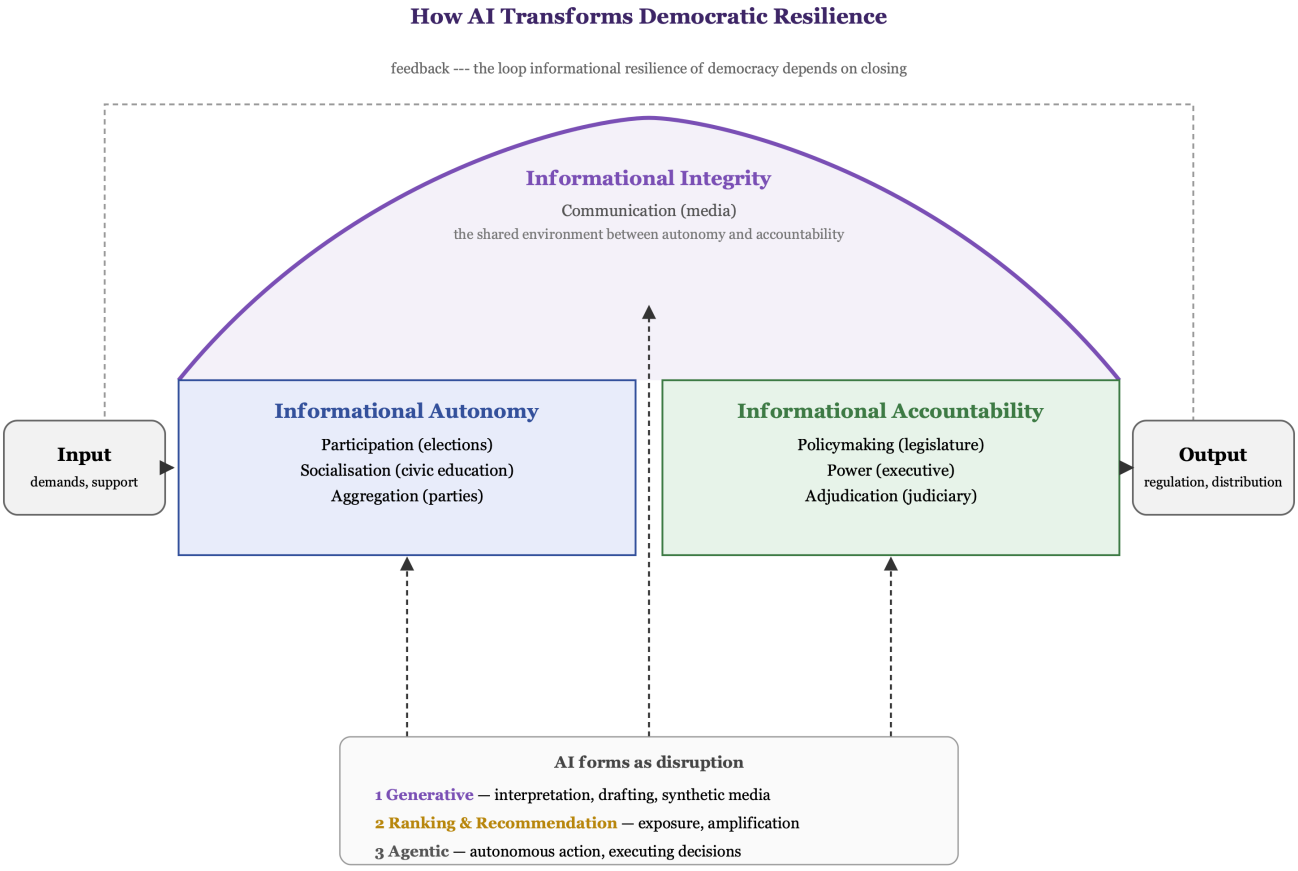


Figure 1: Easton's (1965) feedback loop, regrouped into the three informational components this project focuses on, with different forms of AI as disruption.

pliance and psychological burdens that hamper citizens' access to information and democratic institutions, and can act as a facilitator that summarizes arguments and surfaces paths to compromise within deliberation (Croce, 2025, p. 54). These burdens fall unevenly, and so do the gains from lifting them, potentially benefitting most those citizens least able to navigate complex administrative and informational systems. Evidence shows that conversational agents can widen who speaks as well as how many, improving perceived conversation quality and democratic reciprocity and raising participation among under-represented groups (Argyle et al., 2023), and AI-augmented representative deliberation has been proposed as a way to make participatory processes workable at scales previously out of reach (Noveck, 2026; Ovadya, 2023, pp. 163, 166) — but only where citizens retain control over the agenda, the information and the conclusions (Ohren et al., 2026). For informational resilience of democracy, then, the key question is not whether citizens use AI, but whether they remain the authors of the demands that enter the political system, and whether all citizens do so on equal terms.

1.2 Informational integrity — the shared environment

Informational integrity is the extent to which the shared evidence base circulating through the democratic feedback loop is accurate, authentic, and pluralistic (OECD, 2024, p. 14). Democracy requires citizens to understand how political institutions operate and to access evidence relevant to competing policy claims (Lewandowsky et al., 2023). In the feedback-loop model, this requirement applies in both directions. On the input side, citizens need reliable information to form preferences, while institutions need information that accurately reflects social conditions and public demands. On the output side, citizens need reliable information about government decisions and performance to evaluate outcomes and revise their preferences. Informational integrity therefore depends on the conditions under which political information is produced, distributed, and amplified (Bennett & Livingston, 2018; Freelon & Wells, 2020). It is degraded when falsehoods, exclusion, or strategic manipulation distort this shared evidence base (Ecker et al., 2026; Humprecht et al., 2020).

AI can weaken informational integrity on both sides of the democratic feedback loop. For citizens, generative models can produce persuasive propaganda at low cost (Goldstein et al., 2024), while deepfakes increase uncertainty about genuine evidence and reduce trust even without direct deception (Lundberg & Mozelius, 2025; Vaccari & Chadwick, 2020). Generative AI may also amplify dominant narratives while marginalizing less represented voices, narrowing the evidence base entering the loop (Kay et al., 2024). For institutions, fluent but unverifiable outputs create "epistemic boundedness" in administrative judgment, the policymaking equivalent of the citizen autonomy paradox (Kim et al., 2026).

Conversely, AI can also strengthen informational integrity, specifically by improving access to evidence and the processing of feedback. For example, evidence-based LLM dialogues can correct conspiracy beliefs or misinformation endorsement (Costello et al., 2024), and synthesize diverse viewpoints into group statements that participants prefer to human-mediated alternatives, while better incorporating minority positions (Tessler et al., 2024). Within government, human-in-the-loop LLM analysis can help officials process large volumes of policy documents and consultation material (Turobov & Coyle, 2026), or systematically analyze citizen input at scales that are difficult to process manually (Bono Rossello et al., 2025).

1.3 Informational accountability — institutions

Informational accountability concerns the information that circulates back from institutions once they act: institutions must make their decisions and the reasons behind them sufficiently visible and well explained for that information to reach those with the authority or capacity to check them, question, contest, and, where necessary, correct or sanction them. This runs on two components — an obligation to explain and justify decisions and actions, and the capacity of others to sanction or correct them when that justification fails (Bovens, 2007; Lührmann et al., 2020; Schedler, 1999) — which the separation of legislative, executive, and judicial power, and the press and other actors that monitor them, are designed to guarantee (Schultz, 1998). An institution that explains itself without ever facing consequences is not accountable, and neither is one that can be sanctioned but is never required to answer.

AI can weaken informational accountability by making responsibility for public decisions harder to trace. As public administrations increasingly rely on AI-mediated information and decisions, it can become more difficult to determine who is responsible for a decision, on what information it was based, and how it can be challenged or corrected (Margetts & Dorobantu, 2019). Hence, AI can widen power asymmetries between citizens and institutions (Nasi, 2025), reshape institutional mechanisms through which accountability operates, such as elections (Jungherr, 2023; Summerfield et al., 2025), and more broadly undermine democratic processes (Altman, 2026; Jackson & Woolley, 2025; Kreps & Kriner, 2023), while also being deployed directly as a tool of authoritarian control (Feldstein, 2021; Garbe & Maerz, 2026). Apart from that, the capacity to demand accountability is itself unevenly distributed. For instance, well-resourced organised interests can compel institutions to provide information, justify decisions, or correct wrongdoing far more effectively than small civil society groups. This makes the transparency and contestability of AI-mediated decisions particularly consequential for citizens who have the fewest resources with which to scrutinise them (Jungherr, 2023).

The same capabilities that can weaken accountability can also be used to strengthen it. This requires designing AI as *democratic AI, meaning* systems developed around democratic requirements such as transparency, traceability, explanation, critical assessment, and opportunities for correction, rather than treating these as safeguards to be added after deployment (Busuioc, 2021; Noveck, 2026). Audit and transparency tools can make AI-mediated decisions traceable, while institutional arrangements can ensure that those decisions and their underlying reasons remain open for critical investigations (Beckman et al., 2024; Cavaliere & Romeo, 2022; Wieringa, 2020). AI can thus become not only an object of accountability but also an instrument for strengthening it, by reducing some of the informational and analytical costs of oversight and enabling citizens and civil-society organisations to evaluate and challenge public decisions (Cavaliere & Romeo, 2022; König & Wenzelburger, 2022). Designed in this way, AI has the potential to narrow rather than widen existing asymmetries in the capacity to hold institutions to account.

2 Summary and research questions for the proposal

The framework opens up a set of research questions that could each become a work package. At its base is how AI-driven technologies, including deepfakes and automated content generation, can

exacerbate or mitigate inequalities and discrimination in democratic life, and how this can be captured in one shared framework. On the information environment, we can ask how AI-generated and manipulated content shapes public opinion, political campaigns and media narratives, how AI-driven cyberviolence amplifies harm against women, children, minorities and LGBTIQ people, which groups are hit hardest and what prevents or mitigates it. We can also ask how inclusive, human-centric tools to detect and mitigate deepfakes, disinformation and cyberviolence can be built with industry partners, and how the concentration of data control and power asymmetries between AI providers, institutions and citizens shape epistemic rights and knowledge production. On citizens, the questions are how their own use of AI shapes their judgment, public trust and political participation, who comes to distrust democracy and why, and which media and AI literacy formats empower citizens, including young people and marginalised groups, to identify and critically assess disinformation and deepfakes. On institutions, we can ask whether AI-supported deliberation, tested in pilots, can include marginalised voices and feed into policy-making, and which policy frameworks, best practices and regulatory measures make AI responsible, trustworthy and transparent under the AI Act, including its use in policy and judicial decisions. Two cross-cutting questions remain: how higher-education institutions can build the capacity and industry collaboration for societally relevant, trustworthy AI research, and how the effects of AI on democracy and equality can be tracked with indicators across countries and over time.

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